

Helios Robotics - Leave and Time-Off Policy (v3.2)

1. Purpose and scope

This policy explains how employees of Helios Robotics earn, request and take time away from work. It applies to all permanent employees in the Munich, Toronto and Singapore offices. Part-time employees receive every entitlement on a pro rata basis. Contractors and interns are not covered by this policy; their leave is set out in their individual agreements. Where local law gives an employee a better entitlement than this policy, the local law applies.

2. Annual leave

2.1 Accrual

Full-time employees accrue 1.75 days of annual leave per month, which equals 21 days per year. Leave starts accruing on the first working day and the current balance is always visible in the Pulse HR portal. Employees may book leave they have not yet accrued only with written approval from their line manager, and never more than 5 days ahead of their accrual.

2.2 Additional days for long service

After 3 full years of service the annual entitlement rises to 23 days. After 7 full years of service it rises to 25 days. The extra days are added on the anniversary date and are pro-rated in the first year.

2.3 Carry-over

Up to 5 unused days may be carried over into the next calendar year. Carried-over days expire on March 31 and are not paid out. Days above the 5-day limit are forfeited on December 31, unless the employee was prevented from taking leave for business reasons and the VP of their department approved an exception in writing.

2.4 Leave on termination

When an employee leaves the company, unused accrued leave is paid out with the final salary. If the employee has taken more leave than they accrued, the difference is deducted from the final payment, except where local law forbids it.

2.5 Company shutdown days

The company closes for 3 days between Christmas and New Year. These shutdown days do not reduce the annual leave balance. The exact dates are published in the company calendar every October.

3. Public holidays

Each office follows the public holiday calendar of its own location. When a public holiday falls on a weekend, no compensatory day is granted unless local law requires one. Employees who are required to work on a public holiday at a customer site receive a day off in lieu, which must be taken within 60 days.

4. Sick leave

4.1 Entitlement

Every employee receives 10 paid sick days per calendar year. Unused sick days do not carry over and are never paid out.

4.2 Notification

Employees who are unwell must inform their line manager before 09:30 on the first day of absence, by phone or chat message. An email alone is not sufficient.

4.3 Medical certificates

A doctor's note is required after 3 consecutive sick days. The note must be uploaded to the Pulse HR portal within 2 working days of the third day of absence.

4.4 Long-term illness

When an illness lasts longer than the 10 paid sick days, People Operations contacts the employee to explain the statutory sick-pay scheme of their country and to agree a return-to-work plan.

5. Parental leave

5.1 Entitlement

Primary caregivers receive 16 weeks of fully paid parental leave. Secondary caregivers receive 6 weeks of fully paid leave. Parental leave must be taken within 12 months of the birth or adoption. The leave can be taken in one block or in two blocks; each block must be at least 2 weeks long.

5.2 Notice

Employees must give People Operations at least 8 weeks of notice before the expected start of parental leave. In cases of premature birth, notice should be given as soon as possible.

5.3 Phased return

After parental leave, employees may choose a phased return of up to 4 weeks at 60% of their contractual hours on full pay. The phased return must be agreed with the line manager before the leave begins.

5.4 Benefits during leave

Health insurance and pension contributions continue unchanged during parental leave. Annual leave continues to accrue during the paid weeks of parental leave.

6. Bereavement leave

Employees receive 5 paid days following the death of an immediate family member (spouse or partner, child, parent, sibling). For the death of an extended family member such as a grandparent, aunt or uncle, employees receive 2 paid days. Bereavement leave can be taken flexibly within 30 days of the death, and no medical certificate is required.

7. Other types of leave

7.1 Marriage leave

Employees receive 3 paid days for their own wedding or civil partnership ceremony.

7.2 Moving house

Employees receive 1 paid day when moving to a new home, up to twice per calendar year.

7.3 Volunteering leave

Every employee may take 2 paid days per calendar year to volunteer for a registered charity. The organisation must be named in the leave request.

7.4 Study leave

Employees enrolled in a recognised course may take up to 5 paid days per year for examinations. Study leave for coursework is not paid but may be taken as unpaid leave.

7.5 Unpaid leave and sabbaticals

Unpaid leave of up to 3 months can be granted with the written approval of a VP. After 5 full years of service, employees may apply for a sabbatical of up to 8 weeks, which is unpaid. Benefits are suspended during a sabbatical, except health insurance, which the company continues to pay for the first 4 weeks.

8. How to request leave

8.1 Procedure

Submit all leave requests in the Pulse HR portal. Absences longer than 3 working days must be requested at least 10 working days in advance. Shorter absences should be requested as early as possible.

8.2 Approval

Line managers approve or decline within 3 working days. If a manager has not responded after 3 working days, the request is automatically escalated to the next-level manager, who must respond within 2 further working days.

8.3 Blackout periods

During the first full week of March, when the annual firmware release takes place, members of Support Engineering may not book leave without VP approval. Managers must publish any other team blackout periods at least 6 months in advance.

8.4 Cancelling approved leave

Approved leave can be cancelled by the employee free of charge up to 5 working days before it starts. The company may only ask an employee to cancel approved leave in an emergency, and must reimburse any non-refundable costs.

9. Frequently asked questions

Can I carry over more than 5 days? No. Only 5 unused days can be carried over, and they expire on March 31. An exception requires written VP approval.

Do the Christmas shutdown days use up my annual leave? No. The 3 shutdown days are given on top of the annual leave entitlement.

Do I need a doctor's note for a two-day illness? No. A doctor's note is required only after 3 consecutive sick days.

Can my partner and I both take primary caregiver leave? No. Only one parent employed by Helios can be the primary caregiver for the same child; the other receives the secondary caregiver entitlement.

Who do I contact with questions? Write to People Operations in the #ask-people-ops channel or via the Pulse HR portal.